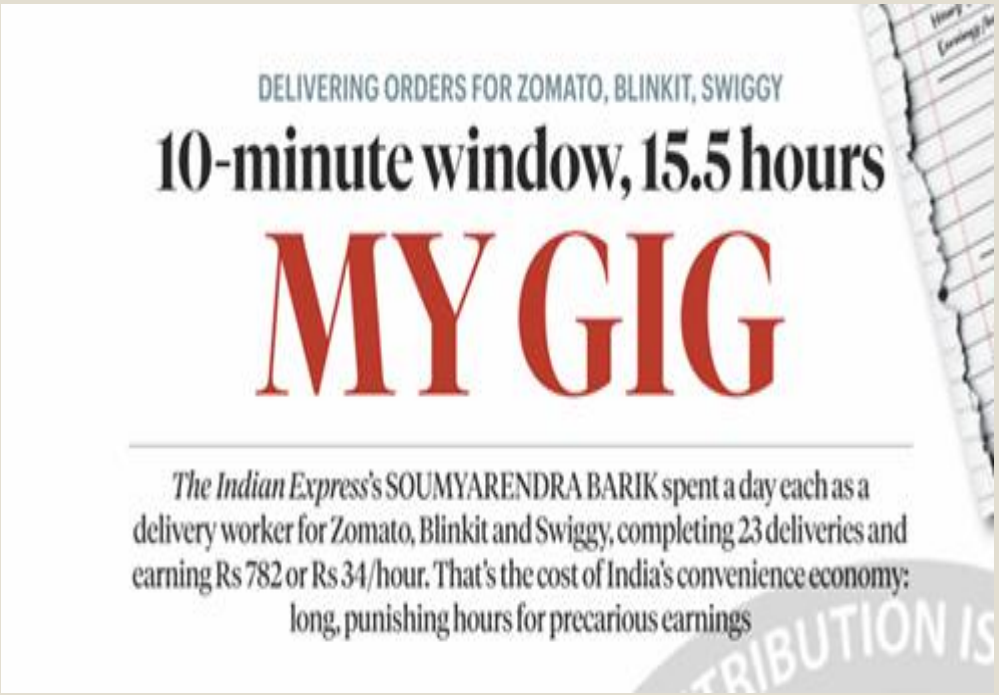
Lets begin with a question

- Have you ever worked in a job that did not satisfy you or you thought you lost your 'self'? Or you were just a 'number' or easily replaceable?
- This is precisely the situation that concerned Karl Marx.
- Lets take another example-
- What do you think about Apple's products?
- What about its labour practices?
- Particularly its overseas suppliers- what happens to them?

Marx and the contemporary times?


DELIVERING ORDERS FOR ZOMATO, BLINKIT, SWIGGY

10-minute window, 15.5 hours

MY GIG

The Indian Express's SOUMYARENDRA BARIK spent a day each as a delivery worker for Zomato, Blinkit and Swiggy, completing 23 deliveries and earning Rs 782 or Rs 34/hour. That's the cost of India's convenience economy: long, punishing hours for precarious earnings

- His ideas remain relevant to think about some of the concerns of the contemporary times.
- Gig economy is one example- can you think of some other examples?

Recent strike by gig workers

ILLUSTRATION: C R SASIKUMAR

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Recent strike by gig workers raises questions about their rights and the responsibility of companies

Exploitation is built into gig work

HIMANSHU

make matters worse, they are sought to be glorified as partners even though the partners have no idea of the nature of the corporation, its profits or even its basic functioning. But it is not just the corporations — even government regulations are silent on treating them as workers. Take the case of the recently implemented labour codes, which were enacted in 2020.

There are no easy villains or answers

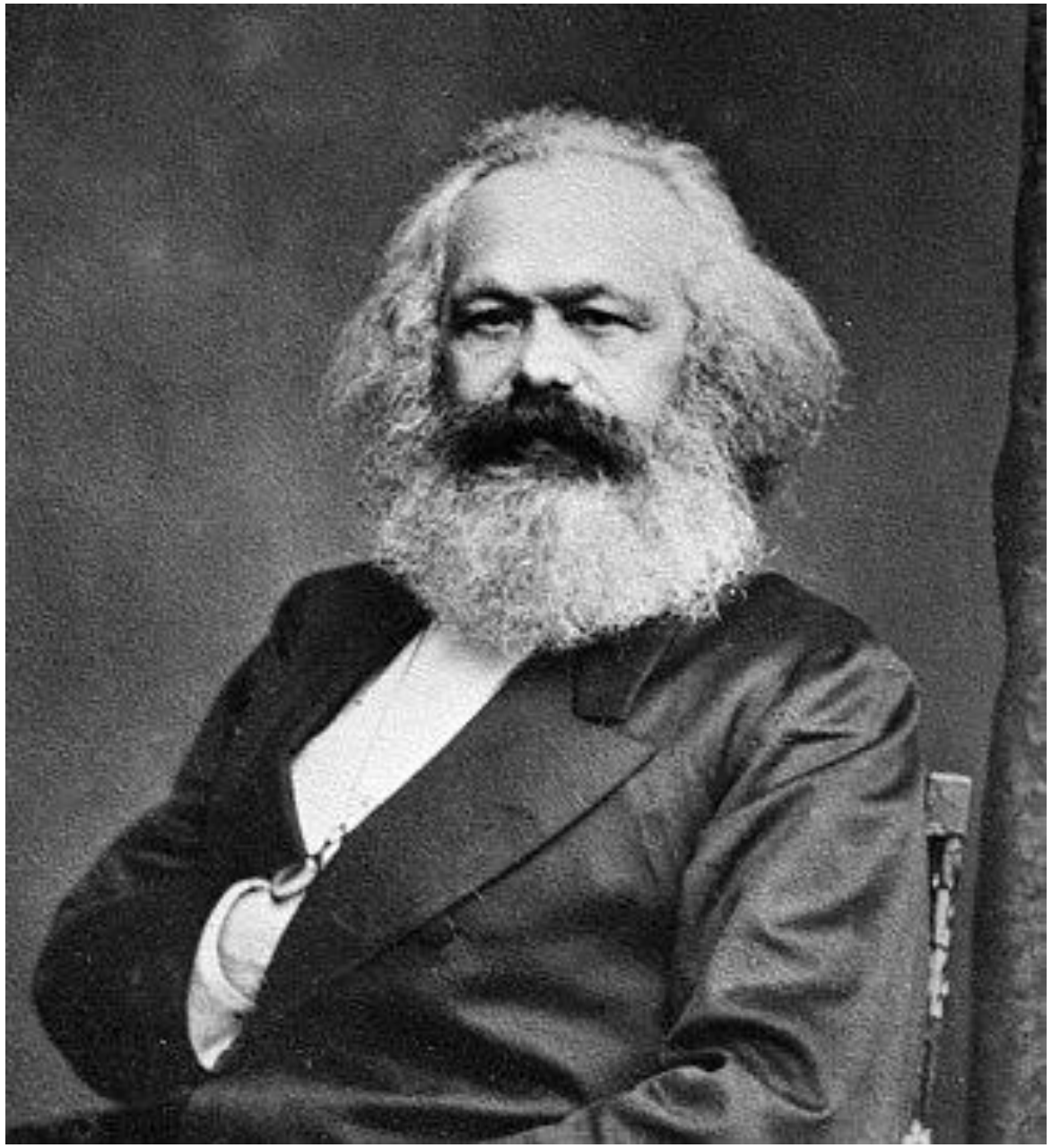
SRINATH SRIDHARAN

favour but merely enabling economic participation. This is all partially true.

But it is also incomplete. Market pricing does not absolve moral responsibility. Nor does flexibility justify the transfer of all downside risk to the worker while upside value accrues elsewhere, including to key investors, without the entities making substantial profits. There is an uncomfortable

KARL MARX (ALIENATION)

Week 5



Karl Marx (1818-1883)

- Why does his ideas remain relevant in contemporary times?

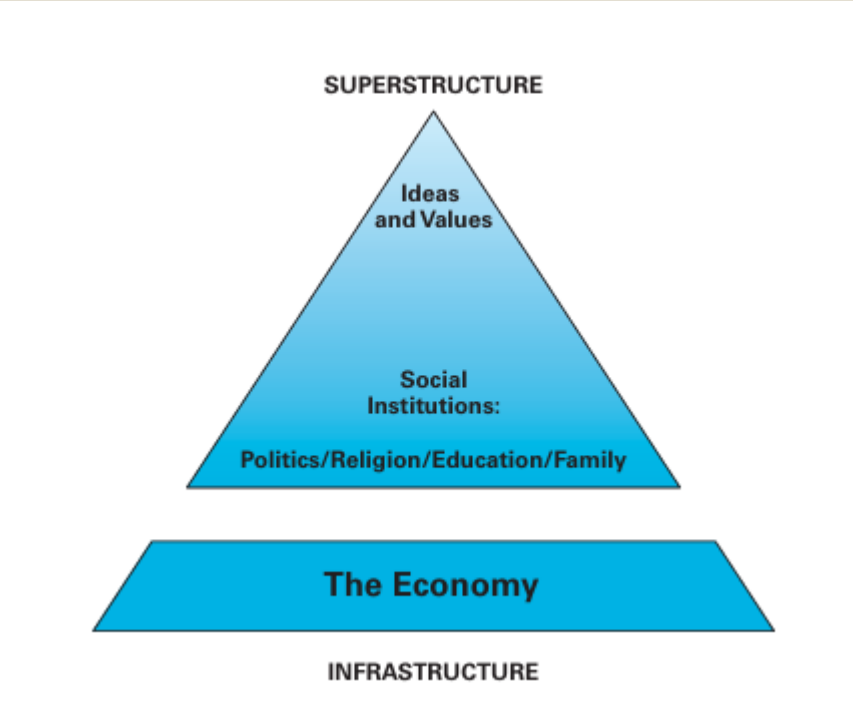
- Let's have a brief look at his biography?
- Social and Economic backdrop
- Germany- France-England
- Not only an academic but also an activist.

Some of the ideas that we will look at

- Alienation (we shall read the original); commodity fetishism
- Materialist conception of history; material base and super structure; Forces and relations of production
- Surplus value; Exploitation
- Class; Class Consciousness
- Bourgeoisie; Proletariat;

Materialist conception of society

- The system of economic production shapes the entire society.
- *Forces of Production* and *Relations of Production*
- FoP + RoP is the 'material life' (already established independent of people's will)
- From this existing economic or material base is born a 'superstructure'.
- The superstructure consists of everything non-economic in nature or "the social, political and intellectual life processes in general".



- A society's legal, political and educational systems (or Superstructure) are all shaped by the economic system or the 'material base'.
- Therefore, an individual's very consciousness- how she views the world is not determined by her own subjectivity but in the circumstances she finds herself in.
- It is itched into our class position in which we are born.
- Marx famously observed,

"It is not the consciousness of people that determines their existence, but their social existence that determines their consciousness."

Classes and Class Conflict

- Two classes:
- Bourgeoisie (in German meant "People of the town")- the *capitalists* or the owners of the property/means of production.
- Proletariat (propertyless workers)- the working class or the labour which has nothing but must sell its labour power in order to survive.
- Private ownership of the means of production leads to class relations based on domination and exploitation.
- The labourers under capitalism themselves become a ***commodity* and are *commodified*** just like the commodities they produce.

“The ideas of the ruling class are in every epoch the ruling ideas”

- What does this mean?
- The dominant class controls not only a society’s means of material production, but the production of ideas as well.
- Lets illustrate this using an example- consider the idea of individual equality.
- Where did it come from?
- The answer lies in dvpt of capitalism.
- Capitalism is based on the notion of “freedom”-how?

Let’s watch a short video-

- https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=fSQgCy_ilcc

False Consciousness

- Why do workers not simply rise up against their exploitation?
- Marx asserts it is due to a lack of class consciousness- collective unawareness on part of the workers about their social and economic standing.
- Workers are distracted for the reality of economic exploitation.
- How?
- The society's superstructure-politics, ideology, culture, religion- distract the workers from realities of exploitation.
- Eg: "Religion as the opiate of the people" (this life and afterlife)
- Social value ascribed to wages paid; think of the 'package' and the talk around it!

Surplus value and Exploitation

- Marx argues that exploitation inherent is in capitalism.
- The surplus value created by the worker through her labour, is appropriated by the capitalist.
- Lets illustrate this with an example-

Alienation

- Perhaps we know what it is intuitively. Do we?
- Karl Marx used the idea of alienation (In *Economic and Philosophic Manuscripts of 1844*) to talk about the working class under the capitalist system of production.
- He saw capitalism as an exploitative system of class relations- pauperisation of working class while the capitalist makes huge profit.

- How is it that alienation is a necessary feature of capitalism? Let us watch a short video
- https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=PZ4VzhluKCQ&t=37s

The idea of ‘Work’ and ‘Labour’

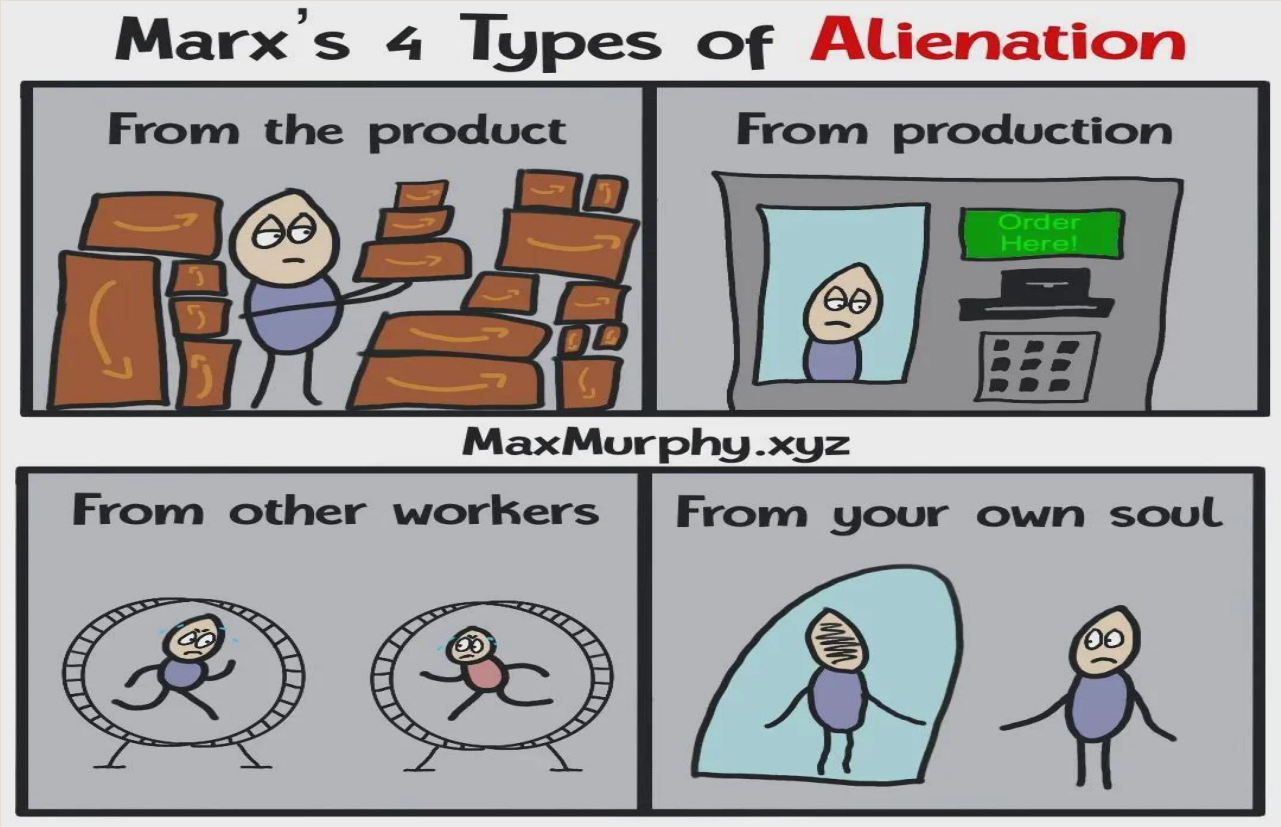
- Marx had some profound thoughts on what (should be) is work and how is it central to being human.
- He tied our ability to work and labour with what he called as **species being**.
- What is that?

- Labour as sth through which we can express ourself but under the capitalist mode of production, the worker merely becomes a cog in machine.
- Performing routinised (and that too parts due to high DoL) tasks and is expendable.
- He thus becomes alienated.
- How?

A mere cog in the machine

Hulton Archive/Getty Images

Four aspects of alienation



Lets discuss these four aspects

- 1. Alienation from the production *process*.
- 2. From the *product* (the products of his labour)
- 3. Alienated from *himself* [sic] and his *species being*.
- 4. Alienation from others (including other workers).

"…the fact of labour is *external* to the worker i.e. it does not belong to his essential being; that in his work, therefore, he does not affirm himself but denies himself, does not feel content but unhappy, does not develop freely his physical and mental energy but mortifies his body and ruins his mind. The worker therefore only feels himself outside his work, and in his work feels outside himself. He is at home when he is not working, and when he is working, he is not at home." (Marx, *The Economic and Philosophic manuscripts of 1844;* 1844/1978)

"…(labour) is not his own, but someone else's, that it does not belong to him, that in it he belongs, not to himself, but to another…It belongs to another; it is the loss of his self."

- “As a result, therefore, man (worker) no longer feels himself to be freely active in any but his animal functions- eating, drinking, procreating, or at most in his dwelling and in dressing up, etc.; and in his human functions he no longer feels himself to be anything but an animal. What is animal becomes human and what is human becomes animal.”

Thus Marx writes,

"If the product of labour is alien to me, if it confronts me as an alien power, to whom, then, does it belong?

If my own activity does not belong to me, if it is an alien, a coerced activity, to whom, then, does it belong?

The alien being…can only be a man himself."

WHO IS THIS MAN?

"If the worker's activity is a torment to him, to another it must be delight and his life's joy."

So is alienation a feature of contemporary times?

- What would you say about the times in which we live?

- Lets do an exercise- what is your worst work experience? (perhaps at an internship you may have done)
- No bad experience? Then what has been a good work experience?

Commodity Fetishism

- Marx and *commodity fetishism*- goods we buy as having ‘magical powers’-
- Our accomplishments and failures are derived not from what we are as individuals, but magically from what we buy as consumers.
- How does it shape our social interactions and our sense of self?
- When we fetishise commodities, we relate to things and not people.
- We blame machines for our dissatisfaction (endow them with human qualities), without realising that their human beings behind it.
- Look at this news report-

From just a few days ago

- We usually blame the machines for our troubles/dissatisfaction, but Marx argue that there are people behind the machines and technologies.

1/28/26, 10:51 AM Meta, Tiktok, Youtube to stand trial on youth's screen addiction claims

• THE BELLWETHER TRIAL IN CALIFORNIA SUPERIOR COURT INVOLVES A 19-YEAR-OLD WOMAN IDENTIFIED AS K.G.M. WHO SAYS SHE BECAME ADDICTED TO THE PLATFORMS BECAUSE OF THEIR ATTENTION-GRABBING DESIGN

Meta, TikTok, YouTube to stand trial on youth's screen addiction claims

Courtney Rozen
Washington, January 26

META PLATFORMS, TikTok and YouTube will face courtroom scrutiny this week over allegations that their platforms are fuelling a youth mental health crisis, as the national debate about kids' screen time enters a new phase.

The bellwether trial in California Superior Court, Los Angeles County involves a 19-year-old woman from California, identified as K.G.M., who says she became addicted to the companies' platforms at a young age because of their attention-grabbing design, according to court filings. She alleges the apps fueled her depression and suicidal thoughts and is seeking to hold the companies liable.

Her lawsuit is the first of several cases expected to go to trial this year that center on what the plaintiffs call "social media addiction" among children, it will be the first time the tech giants must defend themselves at trial over alleged harm caused by their products, the plaintiff's attorney Matthew Bergman said. "They will be under a level of scrutiny that does not exist when you testify in front of Congress," he told Reuters.

The jury will decide whether the companies were negligent in providing products that harmed K.G.M.'s mental health, and if her use of the apps was a substantial factor in her depression, compared with other causes such as the third-party content she viewed on the apps or aspects of her life offline.

"This is really a test case," said Clay Calvert, a media lawyer at the American Enterprise Institute, a pro-business think tank. "We're going to see what happens with these theories" that the social media platforms caused the plaintiff harm.

Mark Zuckerberg, CEO of Meta is expected to take the witness stand. The company will argue in court that its products did not lead to K.G.M.'s mental health challenges, Meta's lawyers told Reuters ahead of the trial. Snap CEO Evan Spiegel was also expected to testify, as his company was named a defendant in the lawsuit. Snap (SNAP.N), opens new tab agreed on January 20 to settle K.G.M.'s lawsuit. A company spokesperson declined to comment on the specifics of the deal.

Mark Zuckerberg, Meta CEO, is expected to take the witness stand. FILE

YouTube will argue that the company's platforms are fundamentally different from social media platforms such as Instagram and TikTok, and should not be lumped together in court, a YouTube executive said ahead of the trial.

TikTok declined to comment about the company's planned arguments in court.

As the trial begins, the same tech companies are mounting a nationwide effort to convince critics that their products are safe for teens. They've launched tools they say give parents more control over how their kids use the platforms and have spent millions of dollars promoting those features.

Since at least 2018, Meta has sponsored parent workshops about teen online safety at dozens of high schools across the US The company hosted one of those workshops, dubbed Screen Smart, in 2024 in Los Angeles, opens new tab, alongside National PTA President Yvonne Johnson and Meta safety chief Antigone Davis. National PTA is a nonprofit that advocates for child welfare.

TikTok also sponsored similar gatherings, opens new tab led by 100 local and regional PTAs, calling it Create with Kindness, according to the company's website. The program included tutorials on TikTok's features for parents, including the option to limit screen time at night, according to the curriculum, opens new tab.

YouTube's parent company Google in recent years has turned to Girl Scouts to convince the public it is invested in kids' online safety. Girls can earn a patch, which features Google's logo, opens new tab, to affix to their uniform after completing lessons about strong passwords, being kind online and digital privacy, according to the Girl Scouts website. The companies have also hired lawyers that have represented corporations in high-profile litigation involving addiction. REUTERS

New Delhi